

PEH Data Platform – User Guide

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User Guide

This user guide describes how to use the PEH Data Platform in a correct and responsible way.

You can navigate to detailed guidance for:

Data Providers - Supplying Data Controllers

Data Users - Receiving Data Controllers

Protocol On the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform

The Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform (“PEH Data Platform”) has been developed at VITO in order to give access and to share single measurement Personal Exposure and Health data (“PEH data”), most commonly originating from population studies, in the highest possible resolution to researchers and other stakeholders.

It is the intention of the Supplying Data Controllers of the data included in this platform, to make the data on this data platform further available to stakeholders according to the terms and conditions of this protocol and the Regulation 2016/679 of the European Parliament and of the Council of 27 April 2016 on the protection of natural persons with regard to the processing of personal data and on the free movement of such data (‘GDPR’, General Data Protection Regulation), and allow additional data to be added to it.

This Protocol describes the terms and conditions on the data exchange between Supplying and Receiving Data Controllers via PEH Data Platform, the role of the PEH Data Platform Manager, as well as the processing activities performed by the Receiving Data Controller.

The **Protocol On the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform** can be consulted at doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19232226

Providing data to the PEH Data Platform and getting access to data from the PEH Data Platform is only possible upon signature of the [Protocol On the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform](#)

To initiate the signature process to sign the Protocol On the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform, send an e-mail to: PEHDataPlatform@vito.be

Register for a user account

To apply for an account to the PEH Data Platform, go to <https://peh.vito.be/> and follow the instructions.

Important note:

Providing data to the PEH Data Platform and getting access to data from the PEH Data Platform is only possible upon signature of the [Protocol On the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform](#)

Overview

This section describes how to provide data to the **PEH Data Platform**.

It focuses on:

- required input structures
- data validation: supported checks and inspections
- known limitations

Conceptual workflow

Providing data to the PEH Data Platform typically follows these steps:

1. The data provider signs the Protocol
2. A codebook is prepared together with the data platform manager
3. The data platform build the project configuration in the PEH Data Platform
4. The data provider receives a tailored data template to provide the data
5. The data provider requests a user account to the PEH Data Platform
6. The data provider runs services in the PEH Data Platform on the filled out data template:
 - data validation

- data enrichment
 - summary statistics
7. The data provider inspects the outputs and upon approval, proceeds to data upload to the PEH Data Platform
-

Limitations and responsibilities

! Important

The PEH Data Platform is a **supporting tool**.

It does **not**: - guarantee regulatory or ethical compliance - detect conceptual errors in study design - replace formal data submission checks

Responsibility for data quality remains with the data provider.

Data requirements

This page describes the **data requirements** for using the **PEH Data Platform**.

It explains:

- which data structures are expected
- the role of templates and codebooks

This information is essential for correct and consistent use of the platform.

Requirements

The PEH Data Platform assumes that data providers:

- work with **predefined data templates** (download link will follow)
- follow **agreed codebooks** (click to download)
- take responsibility for data correctness and completeness

The platform supports inspection and harmonisation through data validation services, but does not enforce or modify data.

Codebooks

Codebooks describe the **meaning and coding** of variables, including:

- variable definitions
- allowed values or value domains
- units and categories where applicable

They form the reference against which input data are inspected during the data validation in the PEH Data Platform

Note

The PEH Data platform does not harmonise or recode values automatically.

Data Templates

What is a template?

A template defines:

Input data should:

Relationship between templates and codebooks

Templates and codebooks are complementary:

- **Templates** define *structure*
- **Codebooks** define *semantics*

Correct use of the PEH Data Platform requires alignment with both.

Important

Use of the PEH Data Platform does not shift responsibility for data quality.
Data providers remain responsible for:

- correctness of their data
- alignment with project specifications
- ethical and regulatory compliance

Overview

This section describes how to get access to data from the **PEH Data Platform**.

It focuses on:

- Submission of a **data request**
 - Data extract codebook and format
-

Legal and ethical framework

Requests may involve **sensitive personal data**, including health data.

All processing must comply with applicable national and EU legal and ethical requirements.

All data requests are subject to the

Protocol on the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform.

Reference

Protocol on the management and use of the Personal Exposure and Health Data Platform.

Zenodo. <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.1923226>

Data access request

Access to **individual-level data** stored in the **Personal Exposure and Health (PEH) Data Platform** is granted on request and subject to approval.

Who can request access?

Data access requests can be submitted by a **Receiving Data Controller (RDC)** for research projects in the public interest, in line with the objectives of the PEH Data Platform.

If multiple RDCs are involved in the same research project, and they require **different subsets of data**,

each RDC must submit a separate request, specifying: - their own research questions, and - the specific data requested.

Data access procedure

Step-by-step

1. The RDC submits a **Data Access Request Form**
 - Via **Microsoft Forms**.
 - To prepare for a form submission, you may consult the corresponding word version [here](#).
 - Provides the required annexes as instructed in the form.
 - Selection of **studies**:
 - Selection of **variables**:

i Note

If your request concerns variables from HBM4EU, download the required Annex to select variables from: <https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.20118883>

2. The request is reviewed by the **Data Request Access Committee (DRAC)**, including a data minimisation check.
The original data providers (**Supplying Data Controllers – SDCs**) may object to the request.
3. If approved, access is granted:
 - to the requested subset of PEH data (studies and variables),
 - filtered to studies for which no SDC objection was raised, and
 - **only after signature of the Protocol** by the RDC (<https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.19232226>).
4. Approved data extracts are made available through the PEH Data Platform: <https://peh.vito.be/>

To avoid requesting data for research questions that have already been explored, it is advised to browse the Publications section in this user guide prior to submitting your request.

Information required in the Data Access Request Form

The Data Access Request Form collects the following information.

1. Project identification

- Main project name (acronym and full name)
- Research project title
- Date of submission

2. Scientific context

- Scientific background
- Objective and specific research questions

3. Methods

- Study design
- Target population
(*e.g. age groups, sex, inclusion/exclusion criteria*)

4. Requested data

- Requested datasets and studies
- Requested variables

Requested data **must be specified using the official annex files** generated via this application.

5. Data analysis plan

- Statistical methods and analytical models
- Sensitivity or pooled analyses (if applicable)
- Requirements for data comparability

6. Data minimisation

- Explicit declaration that only data strictly necessary to answer the research questions are requested

7. Administrative information

- Responsible person and institution
 - Contact details
 - Data analysts and (if applicable) external data processors
 - Planned study start and end dates
 - Publication intentions
-

Required annex files (generated via this app)

To complete a Data Access Request, **two annex files are required**. Both must be **downloaded from this application**.

Annex – Studies

Download the **Annex – Studies** file(s) from [Studies](#).

For each study you request: - set `request_stud_1isYes = 1`

All studies marked with `request_stud_1isYes = 1` are included in the request.

Annex – Variables

Download the **Annex – Variables** file(s) from the [Codebooks](#)

For each variable you request: - set `request_var_1isYes = 1`

All variables marked with `request_var_1isYes = 1` are included in the request.

Only annex files **generated and completed via the Studies and Codebooks sections of this application** are accepted.

Questions?

For questions regarding data availability or the data access procedure, please contact:
PEHDataPlatform@vito.be